piece called *ana mish politi*, literally “I am not political”. An ironic name, of course: the title was a mix of Arabic and Hebrew, which was itself a political decision at a prestigious Israeli event. Midway through the performance, both men recited Darwish’s poem, in their own native tongue. “*Tirshom, gam ani aravi”*, Tzabari said, his fist raised in the air, “write down, I am also an Arab. *Aval b’negud Darwish Mahmoud, ani aravi min al-yehud*. But unlike Mahmoud Darwish, I am an Arab from the Jews.”

It was all too much for Regev, who got up from her seat and stormed out early in the performance. A theatrical flourish, and one that generated the desired headlines—though had she stayed, she might have enjoyed the rest of the number, which quickly turned into a criticism of racism on the left. “The robbed Cossack who mourns in English about ethnic cleansing in the Jewish state,” Tzabari continued, adding a bit of a Mizrahi accent to his Hebrew, a few guttural *ayns* and trilled *reshes*. “They speak of equality, coexistence and liberty… but fear and constantly ignore the hyphen that connects Arab to Jew.”

Beat the left

In August, after a Tunisian man had got behind the wheel of a truck and killed eighty-six people on the promenade in Nice, a number of French towns decided to ban the burkini, the full-body swimsuit designed for observant Muslim women. The ban was short-lived. Photos of four French policemen ordering a woman to remove her burkini on the beach triggered worldwide outrage, and the country’s top administrative court soon overturned the laws.

Israelis were mostly confused by the whole affair: the beaches here are all a mix of skimpy bikinis and conservative clothes, for Jewish and Muslim women alike. A poll by the Israel Democracy Institute found that nearly two-thirds of Israeli Jews think democratic governments have no business dictating dress codes.

Yet on 28 August, Israel had its own swimwear controversy, though it was the opposite of *l’affaire burkini*. Hanna Goor, a singer and former reality-show star, was booted off the stage at a cultural event in Ashdod, a port city south of Tel Aviv, because she was wearing a bikini top. Organizers asked her to cover up, and she refused. The culture ministry, which had sponsored the event, explained that her attire was not